

UDAAN SOCIETY



SOCIAL AND ENVIRONMENTAL POLICY

सामाजिक एवं पर्यावरणीय नीति

Promoting WASH, Health, Education & Environmental Sustainability

Document Reference

Policy Version: 1.0 | Effective Date: June 2026

Next Review: June 2027

Approved by: Executive Committee, UDAAN Society

Registered Office

8/140, Raghuvir Puri GT Road Aligarh

www.udaansociety.org



1. Preamble and Organizational Overview

UDAAN Society is a non-governmental organization registered in District Aligarh, Uttar Pradesh, committed to improving the lives of marginalized communities through integrated development programs focusing on Water, Sanitation, and Hygiene (WASH), health, education, and livelihood promotion. Operating with support from different national and International organizations and in alignment with Government of India flagship schemes — including Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM), Swachh Bharat Mission-Gramin (SBM-G), and Poshan Abhiyan — UDAAN Society recognizes its dual accountability: to the communities it serves and to the environment within which it operates.

This Social and Environmental Policy (SEP) reflects UDAAN Society's formal commitment to ensuring that all its programmes, operations, and partnerships uphold the highest standards of social inclusion, environmental responsibility, human rights, and ethical conduct. This policy is aligned with national regulatory frameworks, international development standards, and the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

2. Vision, Mission, and Core Values

2.1 Vision

A just, equitable, and environmentally sustainable society in which every individual — regardless of gender, caste, religion, or economic status — has access to clean water, sanitation, health, and opportunities for a dignified life.

2.2 Mission

To facilitate participatory, rights-based development processes that empower communities, promote environmental stewardship, and strengthen the capacities of local governance institutions in Uttar Pradesh.

2.3 Core Values

Aspect	Commitment / Action
Equity & Inclusion	Ensuring equal opportunity and access for all, with special focus on women, children, Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and Persons with Disabilities.
Transparency	Maintaining open, honest, and accountable relationships with communities, donors, and government partners.
Environmental Stewardship	Promoting practices that protect natural resources, reduce pollution, and support ecological balance.
Community Participation	Placing communities at the centre of all planning, implementation, and monitoring processes.
Non-Discrimination	Zero tolerance for discrimination based on caste, gender, religion, age, disability, or socioeconomic status.
Accountability	Upholding fiduciary, programmatic, and ethical responsibilities to all stakeholders.



3. Scope and Application

This policy applies to:

- All staff, volunteers, interns, and consultants engaged by UDAAN Society
- All programme activities, projects, and field operations
- All sub-grantees, partner organizations, and vendors working under UDAAN Society's umbrella
- All community-level interventions, including WASH, health, education, and livelihood programmes
- Construction or infrastructure activities undertaken as part of project implementation

4. Social Policy

4.1 Human Rights and Social Justice

UDAAN Society affirms its commitment to universal human rights as enshrined in the Constitution of India and international human rights frameworks. All project activities shall be designed and implemented with a rights-based approach, ensuring that communities are treated as rights-holders, not passive beneficiaries.

- All programmes shall uphold the right to life, dignity, health, education, and a clean environment.
- No individual or community shall be discriminated against or excluded from programme benefits on any grounds.
- UDAAN Society shall advocate for the rights of marginalized groups in its engagement with government and other stakeholders.

4.2 Gender Equality and Women's Empowerment

UDAAN Society recognizes that gender inequality is a root cause of poverty and underdevelopment. All programmes shall be designed with a gender lens to address structural barriers faced by women and girls.

- Women's participation shall be ensured in all community consultations, programme committees, and decision-making bodies.
- Separate sanitation facilities for women and girls shall be a non-negotiable standard in all WASH interventions.
- Programmes shall actively address gender-based violence, early marriage, and discriminatory social norms through awareness and capacity-building activities.
- Menstrual hygiene management (MHM) shall be integrated into all school WASH programmes.
- Women's Self-Help Groups (SHGs) shall be engaged as key partners in livelihood and community mobilization activities.

4.3 Child Protection Policy

UDAAN Society is committed to the safety and protection of all children involved in or affected by its programmes.

- All staff and volunteers shall undergo child safeguarding orientation and sign a Code of Conduct before field deployment.
- UDAAN Society shall maintain strict protocols prohibiting physical punishment, verbal abuse, or any form of exploitation of children.



- Photographs or information about children shall only be used with the informed written consent of parents or guardians.
- Any suspected child abuse or neglect shall be reported immediately to designated Safeguarding Focal Points and, where necessary, to statutory authorities.
- Child-friendly spaces and age-appropriate participation methods shall be used in community engagement activities.

4.4 Social Inclusion and Targeting

UDAAN Society shall actively identify and engage socially excluded groups including Scheduled Castes (SC), Scheduled Tribes (ST), Other Backward Classes (OBC), Persons with Disabilities (PwD), elderly individuals, and religious minorities.

- Social mapping and vulnerability assessments shall be conducted at the start of each project to identify excluded groups.
- Programme indicators shall be disaggregated by gender, caste, age, and disability status.
- Infrastructure and services shall be designed to be accessible to Persons with Disabilities in accordance with the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016.

4.5 Community Participation and Free, Prior, and Informed Consent (FPIC)

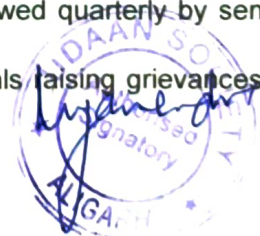
UDAAN Society shall ensure that all community engagement processes are participatory, transparent, and respect the agency of community members.

- Communities shall be consulted at all stages of the project cycle: assessment, design, implementation, and evaluation.
- Information about programmes shall be shared in local languages (Hindi) and in accessible formats.
- Community members shall have the right to refuse or withdraw participation without penalty.
- Gram Sabha resolutions and Village Water & Sanitation Committee (VWSC) approvals shall be documented for infrastructure activities.

4.6 Grievance Redressal Mechanism

UDAAN Society shall maintain an effective and accessible Grievance Redressal Mechanism (GRM) for all community members, staff, and partners.

- A dedicated Grievance Focal Point shall be designated at district and block levels.
- Grievances may be submitted verbally, in writing, via mobile phone, or through community representatives.
- All grievances shall be logged, acknowledged within 3 working days, and resolved within 15 working days.
- Anonymous complaints shall be accepted and taken seriously.
- Grievance registers shall be maintained at all project sites and reviewed quarterly by senior management.
- There shall be a zero-tolerance policy for retaliation against individuals raising grievances in good faith.



5. Environmental Policy

5.1 Environmental Stewardship Commitment

UDAAN Society recognizes that sustainable development cannot be achieved without environmental integrity. The organization commits to minimizing the negative environmental impact of all its activities and maximizing opportunities for ecological restoration and conservation.

5.2 WASH and Water Resource Management

Given UDAAN Society's primary focus on WASH programming, responsible water resource management is a central pillar of this policy.

- All drinking water interventions shall comply with BIS standards for water quality and Bureau of Indian Standards drinking water specifications (IS 10500:2012).
- Water quality testing shall be conducted regularly using Field Test Kits (FTKs) and certified laboratories.
- Programmes shall promote water conservation practices including rainwater harvesting, watershed management, and efficient irrigation in convergent activities.
- Groundwater-based interventions shall include hydrogeological assessments and shall not be implemented in critically or over-exploited blocks without mitigation measures.
- Grey water management systems shall be integrated into household and community sanitation interventions to prevent waterlogging and contamination.

5.3 Sanitation and Waste Management

- All sanitation infrastructure constructed shall include proper soak pits, leach pits, or twin-pit systems in conformity with SBM-G guidelines.
- Open defecation shall be actively discouraged through Community-Led Total Sanitation (CLTS) approaches and behaviour change communication.
- Solid waste management plans shall be developed for each project village, aligned with District Swachh Bharat guidelines.
- Medical and hazardous waste generated during health camps or nutrition activities shall be segregated and disposed of per biomedical waste management rules (BMW Management Rules, 2016).
- Plastic waste, especially single-use plastics, shall be prohibited in all UDAAN Society events, offices, and field activities.

5.4 Climate Change Adaptation and Resilience

UDAAN Society acknowledges that communities across the Globe are increasingly vulnerable to climate-related hazards including floods, droughts, heatwaves, and erratic rainfall patterns. Climate resilience shall be mainstreamed into all programmatic areas.

- Climate risk assessments shall be integrated into project design for infrastructure interventions.
- WASH programmes shall incorporate climate-resilient technologies such as elevated storage tanks, flood-proof platforms, and drought-resistant water supply solutions.
- Community-level awareness on climate change, disaster preparedness, and adaptation strategies shall be included in community mobilization activities.
- UDAAN Society shall align with the National Action Plan on Climate Change (NAPCC) and relevant State Action Plans.

5.5 Green Office and Operations

- UDAAN Society offices shall minimize electricity and paper consumption through energy-efficient practices.

- Staff travel shall prioritize public transport and carpooling; vehicle use shall be optimized to reduce fuel consumption.
- Meetings, trainings, and workshops shall prioritize digital materials over printed handouts wherever feasible.
- Tree plantation drives shall be organized in project areas as part of environmental awareness programmes.
- An annual environmental audit of organizational operations shall be conducted and findings published in the Annual Report.

5.6 Biodiversity and Land Use

- No UDAAN Society project activity shall knowingly cause destruction of forests, wetlands, or habitats of endangered species.
- Land acquisition or use for project activities shall be conducted with full community consent and without coercion.
- UDAAN Society shall not undertake or support activities that pollute rivers, lakes, ponds, or other water bodies.
- Promotion of organic agriculture, kitchen gardens, and agroforestry shall be encouraged in livelihood programmes as environmentally sustainable options.

6. Social and Environmental Safeguards

6.1 Environmental and Social Impact Assessment

Before initiating any new infrastructure project or programme with potential environmental or social risks, UDAAN Society shall conduct an Environmental and Social Impact Assessment (ESIA) proportionate to the scale and nature of the activity.

- A simple Environmental and Social Screening Checklist shall be applied to all new sub-projects.
- Activities classified as high-risk shall undergo a full ESIA before commencement.
- Mitigation measures identified in the ESIA shall be incorporated into the project plan and monitored during implementation.

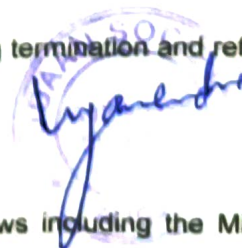
6.2 Prevention of Sexual Exploitation, Abuse, and Harassment (PSEAH)

UDAAN Society maintains a strict zero-tolerance policy against sexual exploitation, abuse, and harassment in all forms.

- All staff shall be trained on PSEAH policies and sign a Code of Conduct prior to field deployment.
- A designated PSEAH Focal Point shall receive, document, and respond to all reported incidents.
- Incidents shall be reported through a confidential, survivor-centred mechanism.
- UDAAN Society shall cooperate fully with any investigation by donors, government authorities, or independent bodies.
- Proven offenders shall face immediate disciplinary action, including termination and referral to law enforcement.

6.3 Labour and Working Conditions

- UDAAN Society shall comply with all applicable Indian labour laws including the Minimum Wages Act, Contract Labour Act, and Payment of Wages Act.



- No child labour shall be employed under any circumstances.
- Women employees shall be entitled to maternity benefits in accordance with the Maternity Benefit Act, 1961.
- All workers engaged on construction activities shall be provided with Personal Protective Equipment (PPE), safe working conditions, and accident insurance.
- Casual or contractual workers shall receive written contracts specifying terms of engagement.

7. Accountability, Monitoring, and Reporting

7.1 Internal Accountability

The Governing Body of UDAAN Society holds ultimate accountability for compliance with this policy. The Executive Director shall designate a Social and Environmental Compliance Officer responsible for operationalizing and monitoring this policy.

7.2 Community Accountability

- Social Audits shall be conducted annually in all project villages with active community participation.
- Community scorecards and participatory monitoring tools shall be used to assess programme performance.
- Project information boards shall be displayed at all intervention sites in Hindi, showing objectives, timelines, budgets, and contact details.

7.3 Donor and Regulatory Reporting

- UDAAN Society shall submit timely, accurate, and comprehensive reports to UNICEF, government authorities, and other donors as per agreed formats.
- Any significant social or environmental incident shall be reported to the donor within 48 hours of occurrence.
- UDAAN Society shall maintain full documentation of all ESIA screenings, grievance logs, safeguard training records, and environmental audits.

7.4 Key Performance Indicators

Aspect	Commitment / Action
Women's participation	In all project committees and consultations
Grievance resolution	95% of complaints resolved within 15 working days
Child safeguarding training	100% of field staff trained annually
PSEAH training	100% of staff and key volunteers trained annually
Water quality testing	Quarterly testing at all UDAAN-supported water points
Environmental audit	Annual organizational environmental audit conducted
Social audit	Annual social audit in all project villages
Grievance register	Maintained and reviewed quarterly at all project sites



8. Policy Implementation and Review

This policy shall be implemented through an Annual Social and Environmental Action Plan developed by the Compliance Officer and approved by the Governing Body. The action plan shall specify activities, responsibilities, timelines, and budget allocations for policy implementation.

The policy shall be reviewed annually or more frequently if significant changes in organizational context, programme scope, or external regulatory environment require it. All staff, partners, and community representatives shall be orientated on this policy upon joining and annually thereafter.

This policy shall be made publicly available on UDAAN Society's notice boards, office premises, and shared with all partner organizations and donors upon request.

9. Related Policies and Regulatory Framework

9.1 Internal UDAAN Society Policies

- Child Protection Policy
- PSEAH Policy and Code of Conduct
- Financial Management Policy
- Human Resources Policy
- Anti-Corruption and Anti-Fraud Policy

9.2 Key Regulatory Frameworks

- Constitution of India (Fundamental Rights and Directive Principles)
- Environment (Protection) Act, 1986
- Water (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1974
- Forest Conservation Act, 1980
- Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016
- Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012
- Minimum Wages Act, 1948
- Maternity Benefit Act, 1961
- Biomedical Waste Management Rules, 2016
- Jal Jeevan Mission Guidelines
- Swachh Bharat Mission-Gramin Guidelines
- UNICEF Core Commitments for Children

10. Approval and Declaration

This Social and Environmental Policy has been reviewed and approved by the Governing Body of UDAAN Society. All staff, partners, and associates are required to familiarize themselves with this policy and comply with its provisions at all times.

